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The New York Times



A demonstrator holding a photo of Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader, who hasn't been seen in public since March.

Federal Move Could Imperil Frail Habitats

By CATRIN EINHORN and MAXINE JOSELOW

The Trump administration on Friday moved to open the habitats of imperiled animals to farming, drilling, mining, real estate development and other activities in what environmentalists characterized as the most severe erosion of protections for wildlife in half a century.

It did so by recasting a single word, “harm.”

For more than 50 years, the federal government has used a broader definition of harm to animals under the Endangered Species Act, a bedrock environmental law. It included any significant “modification or degradation” of habitat that kills or injures animals by impairing their ability to eat, shelter or breed.

The Supreme Court upheld this interpretation in 1995, ruling against property owners who argued that harm should only mean directly killing or injuring an endangered animal.

But on Friday, the Interior Department and the Commerce Department announced a final rule that rescinded this longstanding interpretation. Under the rule, destroying an endangered species’ nest or habitat would no longer be considered illegal.

The change could open the door for fossil fuel companies, agricultural interests, land developers and others to disturb or even destroy the habitats of vulnerable species. Many species are already running out of places to live, and the new rule is likely to add extreme pressure, experts said.

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Estonia Beat Fentanyl. Next Scourge Was Worse.

By AZAM AHMED

TALLINN, Estonia — Almost no one had heard of fentanyl when it began tearing through Estonia, snatching lives like a bewildering plague.

It was 2002, more than a decade before the drug started unraveling American life. Overdoses in Estonia quickly rose to the highest levels in all of Europe, turning the tiny Baltic nation into the early front of a war that would soon turn global.

For the next 15 years, Estonia fought a rising tide of addiction and death, passing new laws, picking apart the criminal underworld and expanding help for addicts. It

THE NEW DRUG WAR

A Tidal Wave of Synthetics

dismantled clandestine labs and, with them, the last vestiges of Russian organized crime.

And like that, the epidemic all but ended. By 2018, fentanyl overdose deaths had plummeted more than 70 percent, a reversal the United States can only dream of.

A year later, after even more headway, some Estonian officials dared to wonder whether they had rid their nation of synthetic opioids altogether.

Perhaps, they thought, their war on drugs was over. Maybe they had actually won.

Only, the war was just beginning.

New synthetic drugs soon began circulating on Estonian streets, many of them so much deadlier that addicts and officers alike said they missed the seemingly simpler days of fentanyl.

“We wish we still had a fentanyl problem,” said Raigo Aas, the chief prosecutor for organized crime in Estonia.

The first new drugs to arrive, known as nitazenes, sent mortality rates skyrocketing again, proving even more addictive and harder to treat or quit. New varieties keep popping up, too, some more than 40 times stronger than fentanyl.

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Triin Trofimov with a photograph her son Jonas Meetua, 18, who died of a nitazene overdose.

Houston to Investigate Fatal Shooting of Immigrant by ICE Agent

By POOJA SALHOTRA and ORLANDO MAYORQUÍN

Hours after three witnesses questioned the official account of how an immigration agent killed a man in Houston this week, city officials said they would begin their own investigation of the federal government’s actions.

Mayor John Whitmire of Houston said he, the city’s police department and the district attorney’s office would work ag-

gressively to obtain all evidence and uncover the truth, reversing his earlier position that the city had no jurisdiction over the case.

“We are not settling to wait for an F.B.I. report,” Mr. Whitmire said during a news briefing on Friday afternoon. “We want answers.”

The episode began about 6:50 a.m. on Tuesday as Lorenzo Salgado Araujo, a 52-year-old Mexican immigrant, was driving in East Houston on his way to work

Witnesses Call Official Account Inaccurate

at a construction site in a van with three other workers. Agents with Immigration and Customs Enforcement began tailing him.

On Friday, the agency said in a statement that Mr. Araujo had rammed an ICE vehicle, had not followed orders and had tried to

run over an officer. An ICE agent fired in self-defense, the statement said. Mr. Araujo was shot in the abdomen and taken to a hospital, where he died.

No evidence was provided to support ICE’s account.

On Friday, the three men with Mr. Araujo said through a lawyer that he had not used his vehicle as a weapon or tried to run over the immigration officers. The men were arrested and provided their

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During Crises, Leader of Iran Is Out of View

Only Ayatollah’s Rulings Can Unify Factions

By YEGANEH TORBATI

Iran is grappling with a devastated economy, a restive population and the ever-present threat of a return to all-out war. And yet, there is a looming absence at the top of the government, with Iranians still waiting to see or hear directly from their supreme leader.

Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei was appointed to the role in March, days after U.S.-Israeli strikes at the outset of the war killed his father and predecessor, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, but he hasn’t been seen in public since. That has led some to wonder not only about the health of Mojtaba Khamenei, who was injured in the attack, but also whether he is really running Iran at this pivotal moment for the country.

He has offered no clear public guidance on a clash between the hard-liners who oppose any diplomacy with the United States and the pragmatists, including Iran’s president and foreign minister, who agreed to a preliminary cease-fire deal with the United States last month.

Such fissures, while nothing new within the country’s fractured political class, are all the more urgent as Iran and the United States trade attacks and diplomatic efforts falter. The divisions spilled into the open this week when Iran’s president, Masoud Pezeshkian, and foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, appeared to be jeered and harassed during the elder Ayatollah Khamenei’s funeral procession.

The supreme leader is entrusted with commanding Iran’s military; deciding the head of the judiciary and various key positions; declaring war and peace; and other critical leadership functions. In Iran’s blended system of theocratic and republican elements, it is the office that holds ultimate primacy.

There was some expectation that Iran and the world would get their first glimpse of the new Ayatollah Khamenei this week, during his father’s funeral. But, on Thursday, the ceremonies concluded without an appearance.

Without a strong central authority like the elder Ayatollah Khamenei, it has become even more unpredictable which faction

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THE WEATHER
Today, some sun, thunderstorms in spots, high 81. **Tonight**, dry, partly cloudy, low 67. **Tomorrow**, mostly sunny, less humid, a light breeze, high 83. Weather map, Page B8.

SECURITY SUBPAR ON AIR FORCE ONE GIVEN BY QATARIS

RETROFIT SCRUTINIZED

Experts Say a Lack of Defensive Elements Could Pose Risk

This article is by Tyler Pager, Eric Lipton, Adam Goldman, Eric Schmitt and Julian E. Barnes.

The new Air Force One, which President Trump flew on earlier this week to Turkey, lacks the same defensive countermeasures that were security features of the old model, including its advanced antimissile capabilities, according to multiple officials who have been briefed on how the jet was retrofitted.

Experts say the absence of those capabilities on the Boeing 747-8 aircraft, which was donated by Qatar, creates potential risk in using the jet abroad, a dynamic underscored by the abrupt decision on Wednesday for Mr. Trump to leave Turkey on the old Air Force One at the urging of the Secret Service.

The episode is intensifying the focus on Mr. Trump’s demands to rapidly retrofit the donated 747 to replace an aging fleet that had served as the official presidential planes.

Lawmakers have called on the administration to disclose whether the overhaul of the Qatari plane, which the Air Force oversaw in the course of the last year, provided sufficient security upgrades. The safety of the aircraft is critical not only for the president, but also for the large entourage of White House staff, Secret Service officials, journalists and guests who fly aboard.

Mr. Trump pushed for the new plane to be put into use as quickly as possible and frequently complained that the old presidential aircraft was not impressive enough to take on international trips.

On Thursday, the White House did not address specific questions about the new plane’s capabilities, but defended its safety.

“The new Air Force One is a state-of-the-art aircraft that has been fitted with high-level security protocols that ensure the safety of the president and his staff,” Steven Cheung, the communication director, said.

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Decades Late, Museum Works To Return Native Hair Samples

By ZACHARY SMALL

On a winter day in Nebraska, two girls living at a boarding school about 230 miles from their home on the Rosebud Sioux Tribe reservation faced an anthropologist and a pair of scissors.

The girls, Amy and Rose Cordier, were attending a school designed to erase Native American identity, where at least 86 children died amid manual labor, physical abuse and forced religious conversions.

The anthropologist measured their bodies on Jan. 5, 1892. He recorded their ages (7 and 13), tribal affiliation (Sioux) and “racial purity” (half Indigenous). He also cut several strands of their hair, placing the specimens into envelopes that were eventually stored in the American Museum of Natural History in New York and largely forgotten until a researcher pulled them from a cabinet in the 1990s.

At that point, a federal law was already in place that required institutions to repatriate Native American remains in their collections. That included skulls and other bones. But for decades,



The American Museum of Natural History holds about 2,700 Native hair clippings.

some museums interpreted the law as excluding hair, even though Native groups and government officials insisted otherwise.

In 2022, Harvard’s Peabody Museum decided its collection of Indigenous hair clippings needed to be returned. Then in 2024, the federal government updated its regulations to remove ambiguities in the law, adding a mention of hair as an example of human remains. Hair clippings must be re-

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BUSINESS B1-5

Why You’re Freezing at Work

During summer, office temperatures are typically set in the low 70s. Where you sit can make you feel colder.

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Threads Finds Its Community

The social platform that Meta once set up as a rival to Elon Musk’s X now has 500 million monthly users.

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NATIONAL A12-17, 20

Women Mixed on Platner Exit

In Maine, many women believe the accusers of the former Democratic candidate, but also grieve the demise of his promising campaign.

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‘A Gold Rush Situation’

Home sellers in San Francisco are asking for stock in OpenAI and Anthropropic instead of cash.

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ARTS C1-6

Her Face Is Her Canvas

The artist Orlan is using herself as a statement as she lectures about changing perceptions of beauty.

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OBITUARIES B11-12

Argentine Counterculture Icon

Indio Solari, who wrote Springsteen-like songs and compared himself to Bob Dylan, was 77.

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Dreamer of a Big Dream

Wally Funk, a pilot who wanted to be a NASA astronaut, rocketed to space in her 80s. She was 87.

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INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Deadly Wildfires in Spain

The blaze in Andalusia has killed at least 12 people and left more than 20 people missing. Many of the victims were foreign tourists, the Spanish authorities said.

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Partly Sucked Out a Plane

A 61-year-old man was being treated for friction burns after a window blew out during a flight to Germany from Greece. The flight was operated by the Ryanair subsidiary Malta Air.

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OPINION A18-19

John McWhorter

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SPORTS B6-10

Show-Me Soccer Chops

Kansas City, Mo., the smallest U.S. World Cup host, has a proud sports history, and is making the most of its time in the global spotlight.

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